Lesson 02: Sentence Variety

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 1: Refining Sentences and Punctuation

Adapted from College ESL Writers: Applied Grammar and Composing Strategies for Success by Barbara Hall and Elizabeth Wallace, Georgia State University - Perimeter College (CC BY-NC-SA): 2.1: Sentence Variety.

In this lesson

A paragraph can contain all the right information and still be dull if every sentence has the same length and the same subject-verb-object pattern. In this lesson you learn six techniques that experienced writers use: three ways to vary the beginning of a sentence and three ways to connect ideas. Used with control, they make your academic writing less choppy and let you decide which idea receives the emphasis.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Explain how sentence variety reduces repetition and adds emphasis.
- Begin sentences with an adverb, a prepositional phrase or an inverted subject and verb, with correct punctuation.
- Combine two sentences with an -ing or -ed modifier without creating a dangling modifier.
- Combine sentences with a relative clause or an appositive, using commas for nonessential information.
- Revise a choppy paragraph for variety.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
sentence variety	a mixture of sentence lengths, patterns and openings	Experienced writers mix it up by using an assortment of sentence patterns, rhythms, and lengths.
choppy	broken into many short sentences of the same kind	I have helped increase funding for local schools. I have reduced crime rates in the neighborhood.
rhetorical question	a question asked for effect, not for an answer	Why fix what isn't broken?
rule of three	the idea that a series of three items is more memorable and satisfying than any other number	Try to use a series of three when providing examples, grouping adjectives, or generating a list.
emphasis	special importance given to one part of a sentence	Words at the beginning or end of a sentence generally receive the greatest emphasis.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
inverted sentence	a sentence in which the verb comes before the subject	Attached is a copy of the file.
modifier	a word or phrase that qualifies the meaning of another element in the sentence	Checking the computer system, Steve discovered a virus.
dangling modifier	a modifier that is not followed by the word it describes	(wrong) By electing me, I will continue ...
relative clause	a clause that begins with who, whose, whom, which or that and describes a noun	The managing director, who lives in Seattle, is visiting the company next week.
nonessential information	details that can be removed without changing the meaning; they go between commas	Some economists, who opposed the bailout, argued ...
appositive	a word or group of words that renames a noun or pronoun	Scott, a poorly trained athlete, was not expected to win the race.

Rules and explanations

Why vary your sentences

The election extract at the start of the lesson material has seven short sentences of a similar length and style; the result is a "choppy, unsophisticated" paragraph that does not hold attention. The book's revision combines the first four sentences into one with a series of three achievements (the rule of three), places a short rhetorical question among longer sentences, and joins two related ideas with a semicolon.

Two slips in that revision are worth noticing at C1. After *such as*, the items should be noun forms: "such as increasing funding ..., reducing crime rates ..., and encouraging young people ...". And "by electing me, I will continue" is a dangling modifier, because *I* am not the person who elects: write "if you elect me, I will continue". Remember also: "A sentence is not necessarily effective just because it is long and complex."

Part A: Three ways to vary the beginning

Many writers overuse the simplest pattern: subject first.

Technique	Original	Revised	Punctuation
1. Start with an adverb	She slowly turned the corner and peered into the murky basement.	Slowly, she turned the corner and peered into the murky basement.	comma after the adverb; adverbs of time (yesterday, today, later, sometimes, often, now) do not always need one

Technique	Original	Revised	Punctuation
2. Start with a prepositional phrase	The bandaged man waited in the doctor's office.	In the doctor's office, the bandaged man waited.	the book's examples use a comma after the phrase
3. Invert subject and verb	A copy of the file is attached.	Attached is a copy of the file.	no comma

- **Emphasis:** words at the beginning or end of a sentence receive the greatest emphasis. A fronted adverb stresses *how* something happens and changes the rhythm. A fronted prepositional phrase stresses the place or time. Inversion moves the subject to the end, where it draws attention.
- **Negative words:** when a sentence begins with a negative adverb such as *never*, only the helping verb comes before the subject.
- **Unmovable phrases:** a phrase that describes a noun stays next to it: "I would like a chocolate sundae without whipped cream" cannot become "Without whipped cream I would like a chocolate sundae".
- **Do not overload:** if a sentence is cluttered with prepositional phrases, like the "treasure" sentence in the material, divide it into two.

Part B: Three ways to connect ideas

Technique	Original sentences	Combined sentence	How
-ing modifier	Steve checked the computer system. He discovered a virus.	Checking the computer system, Steve discovered a virus.	add -ing to one verb, delete its subject, add a comma
-ed modifier	The Ramirez family was delayed by a traffic jam. They arrived several hours after the party started.	Delayed by a traffic jam, the Ramirez family arrived several hours after the party started.	the sentence must contain be + an -ed form; drop be and the subject
relative clause	The managing director is visiting the company next week. He lives in Seattle.	The managing director, who lives in Seattle, is visiting the company next week.	replace the subject (he) with a relative pronoun (who); put the clause next to its noun
appositive	Harland Sanders began serving food for hungry travelers in 1930. He is Colonel Sanders or "the Colonel."	Harland Sanders, "the Colonel," began serving food for hungry travelers in 1930.	drop the subject and verb of the renaming sentence; put the phrase directly before or after the noun

- **Keep the main idea in the main clause.** Steve's news is that he discovered a virus. "The managing director, who is visiting the company next week, lives in Seattle" would emphasise where he lives instead.
- **-ing modifiers** show two actions at the same time ("Barking loudly, the dog ran across the driveway") and can also end a sentence: "Maria filed the final report, meeting her deadline."

- **-ed modifiers** come from passive sentences (be + past participle). The book calls *was delayed* "the perfect tense"; it is the passive voice. It also writes "the Jones family" where it means the Ramirez family.
- **Dangling modifiers:** the word that the modifier describes must come immediately after it.
- **Commas with relative clauses:** a clause that can be removed without changing the meaning is nonessential and goes between commas: "The subprime mortgage crisis, which had been steadily building throughout 2007 and 2008, left many financial institutions in jeopardy." An essential clause takes no commas. Use *which*, not *that*, between commas. (In Naomi's paragraph, "optioned" should be "opted", and "This will problem both" should probably be "This will benefit both".)
- **Appositives** go after the noun ("Scott, a poorly trained athlete, was not expected to win the race") or before it ("A poorly trained athlete, Scott was not expected ..."). The book says appositives always take commas; that is true when they add extra information, but a short appositive that identifies which person takes none. In Practice 3, "her colleague Timothy" (one of several colleagues) has no commas, while "her husband, Mahendra" has one.
- Naomi's other excerpts are pictures that are not in your printed material.

> **Note for Arabic speakers**
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> - Arabic relative clauses often repeat the pronoun ("the director who he lives in Seattle"). In English, the relative pronoun replaces it: "The managing director, who lives in Seattle, ..."
> - Long chains of clauses joined with "and" are normal in Arabic prose. In English, a modifier, a relative clause or an appositive often shows the link more precisely and in fewer words.

Practice

1. Starting with an adverb (lesson material, 2.1, first exercise). Rewrite the following sentences by moving the adverbs to the beginning.

1. The red truck sped furiously past the camper van, blaring its horn.
2. Fernando snatched at the bread hungrily, polishing off three slices in under a minute.
3. Underage drinking typically results from peer pressure and lack of parental attention.
4. The firefighters bravely tackled the blaze, but they were beaten back by flames.
5. Mayor Kasim Reed privately acknowledged that the budget was excessive and that further discussion was needed.

2. Inverted sentences (second exercise). Rewrite the following sentences as inverted sentences.

1. Teresa will never attempt to run another marathon.
2. A detailed job description is enclosed with this letter.
3. Bathroom facilities are across the hall to the left of the water cooler.
4. The well-dressed stranger stumbled through the doorway.
5. My colleagues remain unconvinced about the proposed merger.

3. Connecting ideas (third exercise). Rewrite the following sentence pairs as one sentence, using a modifier, a relative clause or an appositive.

1. Baby sharks are called pups. Pups can be born in one of three ways.
2. The Pacific Ocean is the world's largest ocean. It extends from the Arctic in the north to the Southern Ocean in the south.
3. Michael Phelps won eight gold medals in the 2008 Olympics. He is a champion swimmer.
4. Punam introduced her colleague Timothy to her husband, Mahendra. She speculated that the two of them would have a lot in common.
5. Cacao is harvested by hand. It is then sold to chocolate-processing companies at the Coffee, Sugar, and Cocoa Exchange.

4. Revise a choppy paragraph. Cover the book's revision. Rewrite the election extract (the first paragraph under "Incorporating Sentence Variety") in three or four sentences, using at least three techniques from this lesson.

Speak with your tutor

- "Here is my answer to Practice 4: [paste]. Which techniques did I use? Is any sentence now too long or cluttered?"
- "Give me eight pairs of short sentences about memory or sleep from an introductory psychology course. I will combine each pair with a modifier, a relative clause or an appositive. Tell me if any modifier dangles."
- "Read my paragraph: [paste]. Count the sentences that start with the subject, then suggest two places for an opening adverb, a prepositional phrase or an inversion."
- "Give me six sentences with relative clauses or appositives, some essential and some nonessential. I will add the commas."

Read aloud

The mark | shows a short pause. Notice how the pause after an opening adverb or phrase changes the rhythm.

1. Cautiously, | he unlocked the kennel and waited for the dog's reaction.
2. Underneath the heavy wooden table, | the terrified child hid.
3. Attached is a copy of the file.
4. The managing director, | who lives in Seattle, | is visiting the company next week.
5. Scott, | a poorly trained athlete, | was not expected to win the race.

Writing task

Write a paragraph of 150 to 200 words on one of these topics: a person who influenced your education; a psychology topic from PSYC 110, such as how sleep affects memory or how people cope with stress; or an event that changed something in your city or workplace. Draft it, then revise it for variety: use at

least five of the six techniques (adverb opening, prepositional phrase opening, inversion, -ing or -ed modifier, relative clause, appositive), keep at least one short sentence for emphasis, and label each technique in the margin.

Self-editing checklist:

- No more than half of my sentences begin with the subject.
- Sentence lengths vary, and at least one short sentence gives emphasis.
- An opening adverb or prepositional phrase is followed by a comma (adverbs of time may not need one).
- Every -ing or -ed modifier is followed directly by the noun it describes.
- The main idea of each combined sentence is in the main clause.
- Nonessential relative clauses and appositives are between commas; essential ones are not.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

1.

1. Furiously, the red truck sped past the camper van, blaring its horn.
2. Hungrily, Fernando snatched at the bread, polishing off three slices in under a minute.
3. Typically, underage drinking results from peer pressure and lack of parental attention.
4. Bravely, the firefighters tackled the blaze, but they were beaten back by flames.
5. Privately, Mayor Kasim Reed acknowledged that the budget was excessive and that further discussion was needed.

2.

1. Never will Teresa attempt to run another marathon. (Only the helping verb *will* moves before the subject.)
2. Enclosed with this letter is a detailed job description.
3. Across the hall to the left of the water cooler are the bathroom facilities. (Also: ... are bathroom facilities.)
4. Through the doorway stumbled the well-dressed stranger.
5. Unconvinced about the proposed merger remain my colleagues. (Grammatical but literary; in an ordinary academic paragraph the original order is better. Inversion is a tool for emphasis, not for every sentence.)

3. More than one answer is correct.

1. Baby sharks, called pups, can be born in one of three ways. Also: Baby sharks, which are called pups, can ... / Baby sharks, or pups, can ...
2. The Pacific Ocean, the world's largest ocean, extends from the Arctic in the north to the Southern Ocean in the south. Also: The Pacific Ocean, which is the world's largest ocean, extends ...
3. Michael Phelps, a champion swimmer, won eight gold medals in the 2008 Olympics. Also: A champion swimmer, Michael Phelps won ...
4. Punam introduced her colleague Timothy to her husband, Mahendra, speculating that the two of them would have a lot in common. (Note the comma after *Mahendra*.) Also: Speculating that the two of them would have a lot in common, Punam introduced ...
5. Harvested by hand, cacao is then sold to chocolate-processing companies at the Coffee, Sugar, and Cocoa Exchange. Also: Cacao, which is harvested by hand, is then sold to ...

4. (example answer) During my time in office, I have achieved several goals: I have helped increase funding for local schools, reduced crime rates in the neighborhood, and encouraged young people to get involved in their community. My competitor, who argues that she is the better choice in the upcoming election, wants to change what is working. Why fix something that isn't broken? If you reelect me this year, I will continue to serve this community. (Techniques: an opening prepositional phrase, a series of three, a relative clause, a short rhetorical question.)

My notes